STATE SCAN

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AT ODDS Giani Kuldeep Singh Gargaj announces the ostracisation verdict against Bhagwant Mann, Jun. 15; (below) Mann at the Golden Temple, May 7



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▶ PUNJAB

A CRISIS OF AUTHORITY

For the first time, Sikh clergy has ostracised a serving CM, opening a volatile new chapter in Punjab politics

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

ON JUNE 15, FROM THE *FASEEL* (PODIUM) OF THE AKAL TAKHT—Sikhism's supreme seat of authority—in Amritsar, acting *jathedar* (chief cleric) Giani Kuldeep Singh Gargaj delivered an extraordinary verdict. Reading out the decision of the five Singh Sahiban, the heads of Sikhism's five takhts, he declared Punjab chief minister Bhagwant Mann a 'Guru Dokhi' (one who has wronged the Sikh Gurus) and 'Khalsa Panth Virodhi' (an opponent of the Khalsa community), directing Sikhs worldwide not to associate with him. In the same sitting, the clergy summoned every Sikh legislator and minister who had supported Punjab's new anti-sacrilege law to appear before the Akal Takht on June 29.

Religious censure has long figured in Punjab's political history. Yet never before has such a sanction been imposed on a sitting CM. With the assembly election less than a year away, the confrontation threatens to snowball into a full-blown crisis. Opposition parties have already begun fielding leaders with Panthic standing to target Mann, hoping to convert religious disquiet into political momentum against his Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government.

VIDEO BEHIND THE VERDICT

The trigger was a video that began circulating months ago, purportedly showing a man sprinkling liquor on the portraits of the ten Gurus and an image of the slain militant Jarnail Singh